

Dvar Torah Outline — Sukkot, Hoshanot, and “Maintenance” After the Yamim Nora'im

Abstract

Rabbi Shulman addresses a spiritual question at the heart of Sukkot: after the כתיבה וחתימה טובה of Rosh Hashanah, Aseret Yemei Teshuvah, and Yom Kippur, why do we immediately begin saying from his backyard: uprooting a deeply entrenched משל He answers with a vivid “(“save us”) הושענא” vine is like the intense עבודה of the Yamim Nora'im—but lasting change requires ongoing, small “walkthroughs” to remove new shoots before they reestablish themselves. Sukkot, Rabbi Shulman explains, becomes a training ground for sustaining growth throughout the year through consistent spiritual maintenance.

I. The opening question: why are we saying “הושענא” right after judgment?

A. The seeming contradiction

- Rabbi Shulman notes: we already experienced **atonement and judgment**—it is “written and sealed” (כתיבה וחתימה).
- Yet starting Sukkot, each morning we gather around the בימה for הושענות.
 - Meaning of “הושענא”: “Save us, please.”
- Rabbi Shulman frames the challenge:
 - If everything is “great” after the Yamim Nora'im, **what are we asking to be saved from now?**

B. Clarifying the theological frame

- Rabbi Shulman rejects any notion of a “different religion” about salvation.
 - He anchors it in classic Jewish belief:
 - Hashem is “מלך עוזר ומושיע ומגן”—Hashem is the One who helps and saves.
 - He signals that the theme will be developed further over the course of the חג.
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II. A lived מַשַּׁל: the backyard vine that “didn’t look so bad” (1:30)

A. The situation: a vine slowly takes over

- Rabbi Shulman describes noticing over about a year that a **vine/weed** was growing along the chain-link fence around his backyard.
- Because life was busy, he kept **pushing off** dealing with it.
- As Sukkot approached, he decided to clean it up so the backyard would look nicer for the holiday.

B. The discovery: neglect compounds the problem

- When he began pulling, he realized:
 - The vine had spread over **every linear foot** of the perimeter.
 - It had also put down **new roots repeatedly** along the way (a vine crawls, then roots again).
- The removal became far more intense than expected:
 - **Hours of difficult labor**, sore back and arms.
 - Some sections couldn’t be pulled and required cutting and applying poison to kill the stump.

C. The insight: distance hides severity

- From far away, it “didn’t look so bad.”
- Up close, once you’re “in the weeds,” the extent of the problem is shocking.
- Rabbi Shulman’s takeaway:
 - If he had addressed it earlier (e.g., 6 months before), it would have been dramatically easier.
 - **Neglect** allowed it to become entrenched and exhausting to remove.

III. “I AI-ed it”: the key is ongoing follow-up, not one-time removal (4:32)

A. Confirming the correct approach

- After the big cleanup, Rabbi Shulman consulted an online tool to see what comes next.
- He learned:
 - Uprooting was the right first step.
 - But there is **no way** to remove every small root fragment in one attempt.

B. The maintenance plan

- The guidance: once a week (or regularly), do a **walkthrough**:
 - New shoots will certainly appear.
 - Pull the shoots when they're small and easy to remove.
 - The strategy:
 - Repeatedly removing shoots **exhausts the plant** until it dies.
 - Rabbi Shulman crystallizes the principle:
 - The weed "lives underground," so long-term success depends on **consistent follow-up**.
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IV. The nimshal: Sukkot as the weekly walkthrough after Elul–Yom Kippur (5:30)

A. The spiritual parallel: what we didn't notice during the year

- Rabbi Shulman compares the vine to spiritual drift:
 - During the year, a person may sense areas are "not perfect" (e.g., weaker seder discipline, gaps in davening),
 - yet overall it feels "more or less okay."

B. Elul and Aseret Yemei Teshuvah: seeing the overgrowth

- Entering Elul and Aseret Yemei Teshuvah is like coming close and realizing:
 - "What in the world has been happening?"
 - The problem is **overgrown** beyond what one noticed from a distance.
- The עבודה becomes intense:
 - Like pulling deep roots, it feels "endless."

C. Yom Kippur: the massive roots are pulled out

- Rabbi Shulman likens Yom Kippur's full-day עומד before Hashem to the grueling labor of uprooting:
 - With great **סייעתא דשמיא**, one can remove the big roots.
- The result afterward:
 - Things look "beautiful"—learning, davening, and בין אדם לחבירו are improved.

D. The danger: stopping after Yom Kippur

- Rabbi Shulman warns:
 - If we stop now, the effort becomes a tragic waste—it **will come back**.

- Next year, the same cycle repeats—possibly “back with a vengeance.”

E. The solution: small, consistent maintenance

- The “weekly walkthrough” becomes the model for the year:
 - A small investment (even “5 minutes”) to catch new shoots early.
 - Rabbi Shulman positions Sukkot as:
 - A “training ground” for the full year’s sustained spiritual upkeep.
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V. Closing charge: vigilance and steadiness for the year ahead (8:00)

- Rabbi Shulman blesses the group:
 - We should be זריז, זוכה, and זהיר not to let the “weed” overgrow again.
 - With ongoing maintenance:
 - The next Aseret Yemei Teshuvah can be “much, much easier,” בעזרת השם.
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In Summary

- Rabbi Shulman raises a core Sukkot question: why do we say “הושענא” (save us) right after a successful כתיבה וחתימה?
- His backyard-vine משל illustrates how problems can look minor from afar but become severe when neglected.
- The Yamim Nora'im are like uprooting deep roots; real success depends on continued, regular follow-up.
- Sukkot is framed as a yearly “maintenance training ground,” teaching consistent vigilance so growth lasts all year.